

Antinomianism Denial

doc-antinomianism-denial

Soteriology · Denied Errors · doctrine · outside_majority_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Grace empowers the believer to walk in holiness; the moral law continues to function as the rule of the believer's life, not as the ground of justification, but as the contour of the obedience to which the believer is called.

In plain language

The anchor verses connect grace and obedience in their own words, without making law-keeping the basis on which a person is accepted. In Romans 6:1 Paul raises the antinomian question (the worry that since grace covers sin, we might as well keep sinning), should we keep on sinning so that grace may increase, and verse 2 answers with the strongest Greek refusal, 'may it never be' (mē genoito), the optative form (a mood-form Paul uses to slam a door) plus the reason, we died to sin, so how can we still live in it. He raises a second version in verse 15, may we sin because we are under grace and not law, and gives the very same refusal, which shows neither form of the inference is allowed. Romans 6:14 says sin will not master the believer precisely because the believer is under grace, so grace is the power that frees from sin, not a permit to sin. Titus 2:11-12 is the clearest positive line. The 'grace' (charis) that brings salvation appeared, and that same grace is the one doing the training, 'training' (paideuoussa), teaching believers to say no to ungodliness and worldly cravings and to live self-controlled, upright, and godly. Here grace itself is the teacher of holiness. First John 2:4 says the person who claims to know God but does not keep his commandments is a liar, making ongoing obedience the test of real knowledge of God, and 3:4 defines sin as 'lawlessness' (anomia), tying the moral standard to the very meaning of sin, while 3:9 says the one born of God does not go on practicing sin. In Matthew 5:17 Jesus says he came not to abolish the law but to fulfill it, and Romans 8:4 says the law's requirement is fulfilled in those who walk by the Spirit. Read together these texts affirm both halves. Grace produces holiness, and a moral standard keeps shaping conduct, while acceptance rests on grace rather than on law-keeping. Readers still differ on one point the words leave open, whether to name that standard the continuing Mosaic moral law or the law of Christ, but every reading rejects continuing in sin. The apparent tension between ongoing confession in First John 1:9 and the cannot-keep-sinning of 3:9 dissolves on the verb aspect (whether the action is viewed as occasional or as a settled pattern), one being occasional lapse and the other settled practice. The pattern spans letters and gospel, so the support is strong and consistent.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0264	ἁμαρτάνω	hamartano	to sin	43
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	174
G0458	ἀνομία	anomia	lawlessness	16
G0599	ἀποθνήσκω	apothnesko	to die	112
G0720	ἀρνέομαι	arneomai	to deny	

G1096	γίνομαι	ginomai	to be	697
G1785	ἐντολή	entole	commandment	69
G2647	καταλύω	katalyo	to destroy/lodge	17
G2961	κυριεύω	kyrieuo	to lord over	7
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	198
G3811	παιδεύω	paideuo	to instruct	13
G4137	πληρώω	pleroo	to fulfill	88
G5485	χάρις	charis	grace	157

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The anchor texts in their own words tie grace to obedience and shut out continuing in sin, without making law-keeping the basis on which a person is accepted. Romans 6:2 and Romans 6:15 both answer the antinomian inference (the idea that since we are saved by grace, sin no longer matters) with the same emphatic Greek refusal, 'may it never be' (mē genoito), which is the negative particle plus the second aorist optative (a completed-action mood used here to slam a door) of the verb 'to become or happen' (ginomai), parsed V-2ADO-3S (verb, second aorist active optative, third person singular). It is a recurring Pauline formula that forecloses the inference rather than weighing it. Romans 6:2 grounds the refusal in the aorist (a completed past action) form 'we died' (apethanomen) to 'sin' (hamartia), so continued life in sin is a contradiction. Titus 2:12 makes saving 'grace' (charis) the grammatical subject of the present participle 'training' (paideuouosa), training believers to deny 'ungodliness' (asebeia) and to live 'righteously' (dikaiōs) and 'godly' (eusebōs). 1 John 3:4 equates sin with lawlessness through an articular copula clause (a sentence in the form 'the X is the Y' linked by the verb 'is'), 'sin is lawlessness' (hē hamartia estin hē anomia), and 1 John 2:4 makes the present participle 'keeping' (tērōn) the 'commandments' (tas entolas) the test of knowing God, calling the non-keeper a 'liar' (pseustēs). Matthew 5:17 sets 'to abolish' (katalysai) against 'to fulfill' (plērōsai), so the law is fulfilled not annulled, while Romans 8:4 has its 'righteous requirement' (dikaiōma) fulfilled in those who walk by the Spirit, so the moral standard endures as the contour of obedience.

Scripture

Rom.6.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτία, G5485 χάρις

Reasoning. Poses the antinomian inference (the idea that since grace covers sin, we may keep sinning). The verb 'shall we continue' (epimenōmen), a present active subjunctive parsed V-PAS-1P (verb, present active subjunctive, first person plural, the mood used for proposals or questions of deliberation), frames continuance in sin as a live proposal: shall we keep on in 'sin' (hamartia) so that 'grace' (charis) may 'abound' (pleonasē). The grammar sets up the question that the next verse rejects.

Rom.6.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1096 γίνομαι, G0599 ἀποθνήσκω

Reasoning. The answer is 'may it never be' (mē genoito), the negative particle 'not' (mē) with 'may it happen' (genoito), the second aorist optative (a completed-action mood used to slam a door) of the verb 'to become or happen' (ginomai), parsed V-2ADO-3S (verb, second aorist active optative, third person singular). This optative of rejection forecloses the inference outright rather than debating it. The aorist (completed past action) form 'we died' (apethanomen) to 'sin' (tē hamartia), parsed V-2AAI-1P (verb, second aorist active indicative, first person plural), grounds the refusal in a completed change, and 'how shall we still live in it' (pōs eti zēsomen en autē) treats continued life in sin as a contradiction of that death.

Rom.6.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G2961 κυριεύω

Reasoning. 'Sin' (hamartia) will not lord it over the believer, 'sin shall not have dominion over you' (hamartia hymōn ou kyrieusei), a future indicative parsed V-FAI-3S (verb, future active indicative, third person singular), because the believer is 'not under law but under grace' (ou hypo nomon alla hypo charin). Freedom from sin is presented as the consequence of 'grace' (charis), so grace empowers holiness rather than dissolving it.

Rom.6.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1096 γίνομαι, G0264 ἁμαρτάνω

Reasoning. The second antinomian inference (the idea that since we are under grace not law, we may sin freely), 'shall we sin' (hamartēsōmen), an aorist subjunctive parsed V-AAS-1P (verb, aorist active subjunctive, first person plural), because we are not under law but under 'grace' (charis), receives the identical refusal 'may it never be' (mē genoito). The repetition of the same optative formula (the mood-form used to slam a door) at both Romans 6:2 and Romans 6:15 shows that neither version of the antinomian conclusion, continue in sin nor sin freely under grace, is granted.

Titus.2.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις

Reasoning. The 'grace' (charis) of God that brings salvation appeared, 'the saving grace of God appeared' (epephanē hē charis tou theou sōtērios). 'Grace' (charis) is the explicit grammatical subject, which the next verse continues with a participle (a verb form acting like an adjective), so the saving grace is itself the agent whose moral effect is then described.

Titus.2.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3811 παιδεύω, G5485 χάρις

Reasoning. 'Grace' (charis) is the subject of 'training' (paideuousa), a present active participle parsed V-PAP-NSF (verb, present active participle, nominative singular feminine) agreeing with the feminine noun 'grace' (charis), training us so that 'in order that' (hina), 'having denied' (arnēsamenoi), 'ungodliness' (asebeian) and worldly desires, we may 'live' (zēsōmen) self-controlled, upright, and godly. The participle (a verb form acting like an adjective) makes holiness the direct pedagogical aim of grace, which is the affirmative core of the proposition.

1John.2.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1785 ἐντολή

Reasoning. The one who says, 'the one saying' (ho legōn), I have known him, 'I have known him' (egnōka auton), yet does not keep his commandments, 'the commandments of him not keeping' (tas entolas autou mē tērōn), a present participle (ongoing action) of 'to keep' (tēreō), is a 'liar' (pseustēs). The present-tense keeping makes ongoing obedience the test of the claim to know God, so saving knowledge and commandment-keeping are lexically inseparable.

1John.3.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἀμαρτία, G0458 ἀνομία

Reasoning. Everyone practicing 'sin' (hamartia), 'doing' (poiōn), a present participle (ongoing action), also practices lawlessness, and the clause 'sin is lawlessness' (hē hamartia estin hē anomia) equates the two with an articular subject (a noun with 'the' attached), the copula (the linking verb 'is') 'is' (estin), and an articular predicate (a 'the X' completing the 'is' statement). The definitional equation ties the very category of sin to 'lawlessness' (nomia), so the moral standard marks the boundary of obedience.

1John.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0264 ἀμαρτάνω

Reasoning. The one born of God does not practice sin, 'sin he does not do' (hamartian ou poiei), a present indicative (an ongoing, simple statement of fact), and 'he is not able to sin' (ou dynatai hamartanein), a present infinitive (ongoing-action verbal noun), cannot keep on sinning, because the seed of God remains. The present-tense verbs describe habitual practice, so the new birth lexically produces obedience incompatible with settled, ongoing sin.

Rom.8.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G4137 πληρώω

Reasoning. The 'righteous requirement of the law' (to dikaiōma tou nomou) is 'fulfilled' (plērōthē), an aorist passive subjunctive (a completed-action, action-done-to-the-subject mood used in dependent clauses), in us who 'walk' (peripatousin), not according to flesh but according to Spirit. The passive verb makes the law's standard something met in the Spirit-walking believer, so being not under law as a ground of acceptance coexists with the law's demand being fulfilled in conduct.

Matt.5.17 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3551 νόμος, G2647 καταλύω

Reasoning. Christ did not come 'to abolish' (katalysai), an aorist infinitive (a completed-action verbal noun), the law or the prophets but 'to fulfill' (plērōsai). The antithesis of the two aorist infinitives, with 'but' (alla) between, establishes that the law is not annulled in his coming, which underwrites its continuing role as the contour of obedience.

Matt.5.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1785 ἐντολή

Reasoning. Whoever relaxes, 'shall loose' (lysē), an aorist subjunctive (a completed-action mood used after relative clauses), one of the least of these 'commandments' (mian tōn entolōn toutōn), and teaches others so will be called least in the kingdom. The verb 'shall loose' (lysē) marks loosening a commandment as a loss of standing, reinforcing the abiding moral demand without making commandment-keeping the ground of entry.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1John.3.4	Num.15.31	tsk	1
1John.3.8	1John.3.5	tsk	1
Matt.5.19	Deut.27.26	tsk	1
Titus.2.12	Ps.105.45	tsk	1
1John.3.7	Ps.106.3	tsk	1
Rom.6.2	Gen.39.9	tsk	1
Titus.2.12	Isa.55.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Rom.6.14 · addressed

The clause 'not under law' (ou hypo nomon) could be read as abolishing the moral law for believers. The surrounding grammar resolves this. It stands in antithesis to 'under grace' (hypo charin) as the basis of standing, while verse 13 commands presenting the members as 'weapons of righteousness' (hopla dikaiosynēs), and Romans 8:4 says the 'righteous requirement' (dikaiōma) of the law is fulfilled in the Spirit-walker. The verse removes law as the ground of justification (being declared righteous before God) but not as the standard of conduct.

1John.1.9 · addressed

Confession of ongoing sin, 'if we confess our sins' (ean homologōmen tas hamartias), could seem to contradict the does-not-practice-sin language of 1 John 3:9. The aspect (the angle from which the action is viewed: ongoing versus completed) differs. 1 John 1:9 uses 'we confess' (homologōmen) of acknowledging occasional sin that is cleansed, while 3:9 uses the present-tense forms 'does' (poiei) and 'to sin' (hamartanein) of settled, habitual practice, so the two describe lapse versus lifestyle and are compatible.

Rom.6.15 · addressed

Being under grace not law could be heard as licence to sin, which is exactly the inference the verse voices, 'shall we sin' (hamartēsōmen). It is not left ambiguous. The same 'may it never be' (mē genoito) that answers Romans 6:2 answers it here, so the text itself forecloses the antinomian reading (the lawless-license reading) of its own not-under-law clause.

Concordance traversed

G0266, G0264, G0458, G3551, G1785, G3811, G5485, G1096, G0599, G2961, G4137, G2647, G0720

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All anchor verses are New Testament and outside the published CBGM scope (the published reach of the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a way of mapping manuscript relationships), which in this run covers only 3 John. A direct check of the lexical store confirmed VariantUnit nodes exist only for 3 John, so the bundle correctly reports not_in_ecm_scope (not inside the critical edition's coverage) for these passages and supplied no variant units. The load-bearing forms, 'may it never be' (mē genoito) at Romans 6:2 and 6:15, 'we died' (apethanomen), 'training' (paideuoussa), 'lawlessness' (anomia) at 1 John 3:4, 'keeping the commandments' (tērōn tas entolas) at 1 John 2:4, and 'to abolish' (katalysai) and 'to fulfill' (plērōsai) at Matthew 5:17, are not subject to any examined apparatus reading (any manuscript-variant entry under review), so the verdict is treated as variant robust within the available manuscript evidence.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the moral law, summarized in the Ten Commandments, as an abiding rule of life for the believer, which matches the proposition directly. Romans 6:14, Titus 2:12, 1 John 3:4, and Romans 8:4 are taken to show grace producing law-shaped obedience and the law's 'righteous requirement' (dikaiōma) fulfilled in the Spirit-walker, so the enduring-standard clause is read as the continuing Mosaic moral law (the moral content of the law given through Moses).

dispensationalism: affirms · Distinguishes the Mosaic law as a covenant code from the moral character of God, and places the believer under the law of Christ rather than the Mosaic covenant. It still affirms grace empowering holiness and rejects continuing in sin per Romans 6:2 and 6:15 and Titus 2:12, so the obedience claim holds even though the word law in 'rule of the believer's life' is parsed as the law of Christ rather than the Mosaic code.

new_covenant_theology: affirms · Holds that the Mosaic law as a unit is fulfilled in Christ, Matthew 5:17, and that the law of Christ now governs. It affirms that grace trains for holiness, Titus 2:12, that 1 John 2:4 makes commandment-keeping the test of knowing God, and that sin defined as 'lawlessness' (anomia) in 1 John 3:4 remains excluded, so it affirms the substance while declining the specific phrase moral law as rule of life in favor of the law of Christ.

The lexical data supports the substantive double claim, grace empowers holiness and an enduring moral standard governs conduct, across all three frameworks, and each framework independently rejects antinomianism (the view that grace abolishes any moral obligation). The frameworks diverge only on whether the abiding standard is named the Mosaic moral law continuing as a rule of life, the so-called third use (the use of the moral law to guide the believer's conduct), or the law of Christ that fulfills and supersedes the Mosaic code. The vocabulary of the anchor texts, 'law' (nomos), 'commandment' (entolē), 'lawlessness' (anomia), does not by itself rank Mosaic-law against law-of-Christ as the name of the standard, which is the one point the words leave open. None of the frameworks reads the texts as permitting continued sin.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does grace empower the believer toward holiness, and does an enduring moral standard continue to govern the believer's conduct without being the basis of acceptance before God

The stem encodes a specific taxonomy, the moral law continuing as the rule of the believer's life, which is a tradition-laden way of distinguishing the law as ground of justification (being declared righteous before God) from the law as contour of obedience. The phrase rule of the believer's life carries a particular framing associated with the threefold use of the law (the classification of the law's roles: restraint of evil, conviction of sin, and guidance for the believer). The neutralized form tests the underlying claim, grace producing obedience plus an enduring moral standard that is not the ground of justification, on the lexical evidence. VERDICT-CHANGED: not applicable here. The verdict is derived on the original stem and lands affirms because the anchor terms support both the empowerment-to-holiness clause, 'grace training' (charis paideuoussa) and 'sin shall not have dominion' (hamartia ou kyrieusei), and the enduring-standard clause, 'sin is lawlessness' (hamartia estin hē anomia) and 'keeping the commandments' (tērōn tas entolas), while reserving the name of the standard to the lens layer.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.6.2
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.6.15
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Titus.2.12
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1John.2.4
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1John.3.4
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0458
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1785
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3811
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1John.3.4

License audit

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